'Izzat Ghar': The Case of Household Toilets

The pace of construction of household toilets under Swachh Bharat and housing under PMAY-G illustrate the Yogi government's focus on implementing Union government schemes. UP constructed 17.1 million household toilets between 2014-15 and 2019-20, taking the overall tally to 23.8 million in UP and 164.18 million nationally (see Figure 4.2).[35] Importantly, these toilets are not built by the government. Beneficiaries receive ₹12,000 in their bank account and have to get it constructed themselves. They receive ₹10,000 in the first tranche, and the remaining money after the construction is verified and geotagged. Revealingly, Modi began referring to these toilets as 'Izzat Ghar' or 'House of Respect' after seeing this title-plate on some toilets built in Varanasi in 2017. In a country where a lack of toilets has been one of the most obvious yet underrated of gender divides, this terminology for toilets specifically targeted women. As Modi told an election rally in UP in 2019, 'Modi's campaigning is being done by that daughter in whose house a toilet was built under the Swachh Bharat Mission. For a young daughter, this was the making of an Izzat Ghar.'[36] In October 2017, the Union government even issued a circular to all states, asking Hindi-speaking states to start formally referring to Swachh Bharat toilets as 'Izzat Ghar' and non-Hindi speaking states to come up with similar nomenclature in their own languages.[37] (Chapter 17 investigates the gender-specific politics around such schemes in detail.)

Figure 4.2: Construction of Household Toilets in UP Grew at the Same Pace as Construction Nationwide: Swachh Bharat